Is reelection an antidote to the incumbency curse?

Evidence from Mexican municipal races 1997–2025

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Outline

1 Motivation

2 The removal of single-term limits

3 Model

4 Results

Motivation

Does winning office improve a party's future electoral fortunes?

- Not in Mexico (Lucardi–Rosas 2016)
- Coalitions started from scratch at each cycle? (Díaz Cayeros et al. 2016)
- "Incumbency curse" (also in Brazil, India, ...)

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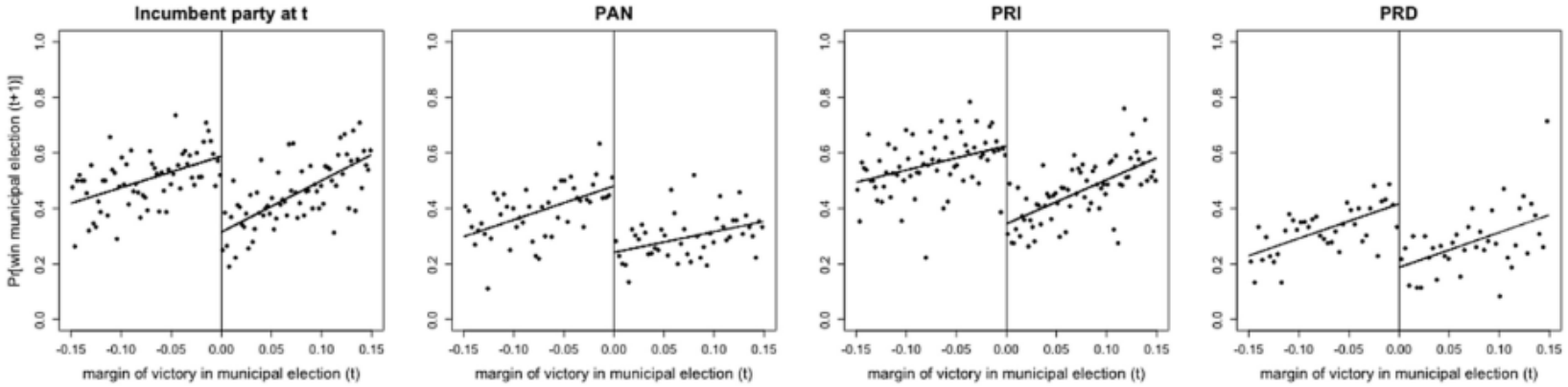
Marginal municipal races 1997–2010, regression discontinuity



Study antedates last decade's reelection reform

→ Could this change the curse into an incumbency advantage? (Erikson 1971, . . .)

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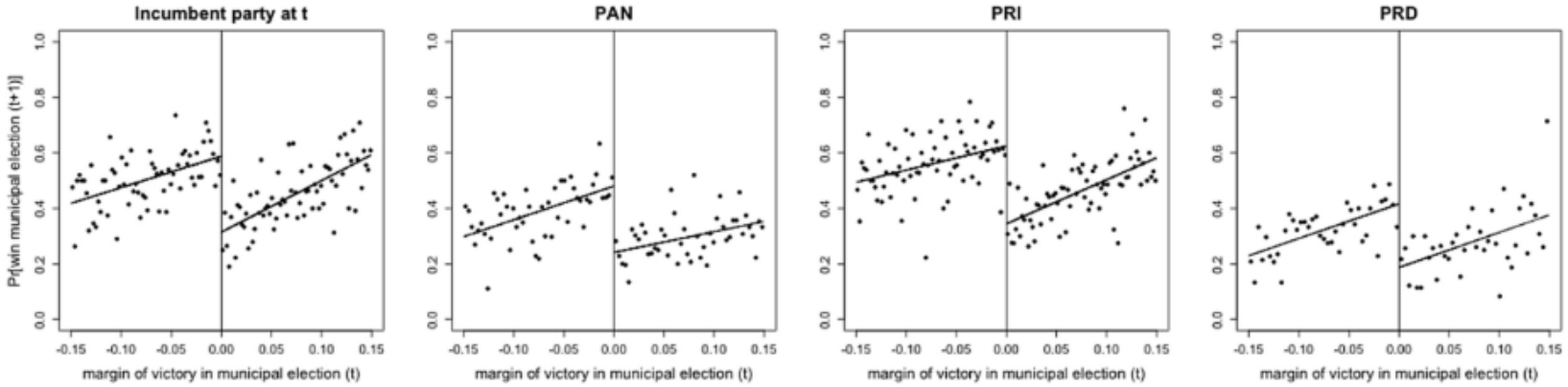

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Electoral reform

Between 2018 and 2030:

- Two-term limits for municipal officers
- Staggered removal of single-term limits:
  23 states in 2018, 3 in 2019, 2 in 2021, 2 in 2024
  (and 2 non-reformers)
- Many municipal presidents on the ballot

Cycle	Incumbent ran	Term limit	Open seat	Pre-kick-off	Total	N
2018–2019	32	0	54	14	100	1,660
2021–2022	36	16	44	5	100	1,741
2024–2025	45	19	36	0	100	1,743
Total	38	12	44	6	100	5,144

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Minimal effects?

Motolinia (2026) state legislators

Relative to rest, members who sought reelection

- 2 % likelier to mention pork in speeches
- spent 15 % more in casework
- twice likelier to sit in pork committees
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Controlling incumbents on the ballot

Switching-regime model:

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+ \quad & (1 - \text{neg}_t) \times (\beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{ocup}_{t+1} + \beta_2 \text{mg}_t + \beta_3 \text{ocup}_{t+1} \times \text{mg}_t) \\
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Incumbency curse hypotheses:

municipal president out	$\alpha_0 > \beta_0$
ran	$\alpha_0 + \alpha_1 > \beta_0 + \beta_1$

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Three obstacles

1. 2018: reform coincided with party system collapse
2. Self-selection
3. Routine coalitions

Willing and able? *ab* confounded

	static ambition	
	0	1
renominated 0	*a* retired	*b* pushed out
1	*c* ∅	*d* reran

Three distinct subsets of observations

- pre-reform (and pre-AMLO): ab_1
- pre-kick-off: ab_2
- post-kick-off: ab_3 & d_3

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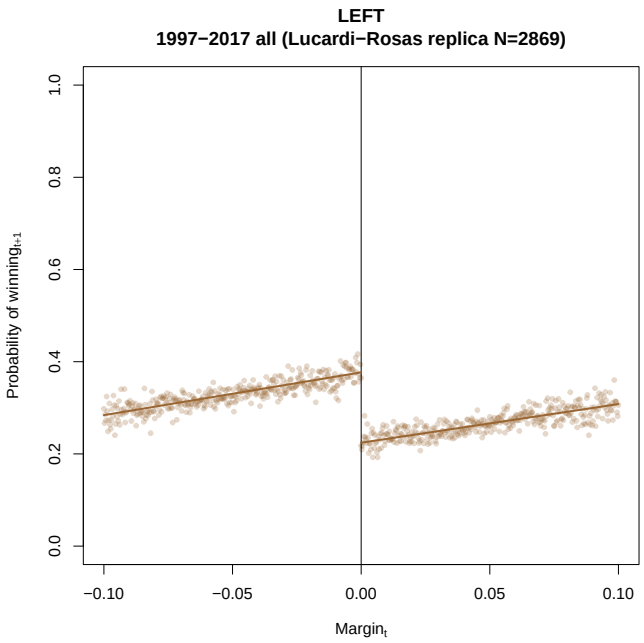
Methodology

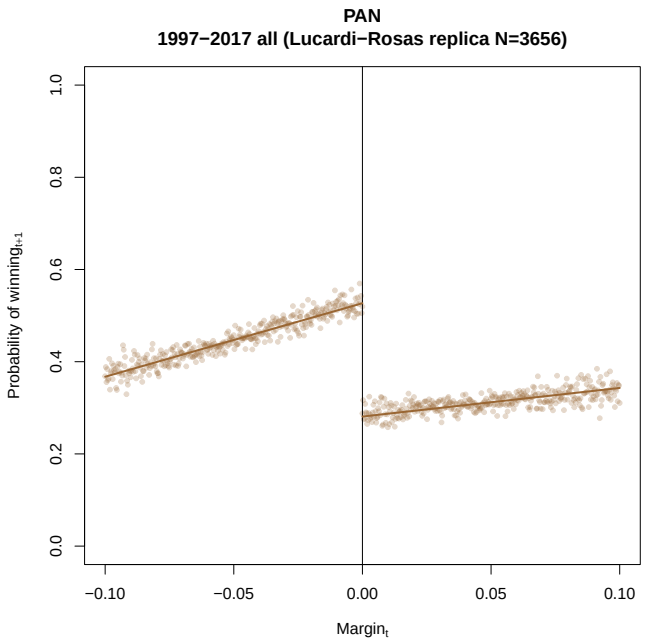
- Marginal ($\pm 10\,\%$) municipal elections 1997–2025
- OLS and MCMC methods of estimation
- Use the different subsets

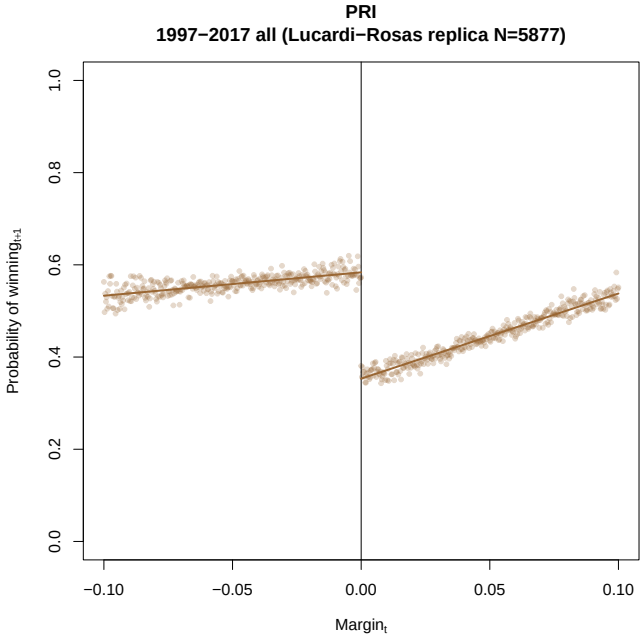
OLS estimations

	Pre-banderazo inicial			Post-banderazo inicial		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Variable	Morena	PAN	PRI	Morena	PAN	PRI
Cuando neg = 1						
Intercept α_0	0.338***	0.303***	0.451***	0.450***	0.284***	0.390***
	(0.100)	(0.092)	(0.097)	(0.047)	(0.034)	(0.034)
mg_t α_1	3.438*	0.128	3.186*	−0.339	−0.589	1.483**
	(1.921)	(1.742)	(1.893)	(0.905)	(0.627)	(0.625)
$ocup_{t+1}$				−0.230*	0.169**	−0.081
				(0.127)	(0.070)	(0.065)
$mg_t \times ocup_{t+1}$				0.859	1.301	−0.076
				(2.305)	(1.304)	(1.205)
Cuando neg = 0						
Intercept β_0	0.174*	0.154*	0.292***	0.311***	0.263***	0.250***
	(0.094)	(0.084)	(0.102)	(0.050)	(0.034)	(0.033)
mg_t	3.480*	1.059	0.409	2.952***	0.987	0.559
	(1.874)	(1.756)	(1.999)	(0.932)	(0.628)	(0.602)
$ocup_{t+1}$				0.012	0.193***	0.143**
				(0.112)	(0.073)	(0.071)
$mg_t \times ocup_{t+1}$				−1.537	0.374	−0.036
				(2.049)	(1.338)	(1.296)
R^2	0.311	0.258	0.325	0.451	0.361	0.315
Observations	121	151	151	906	1,816	1,840

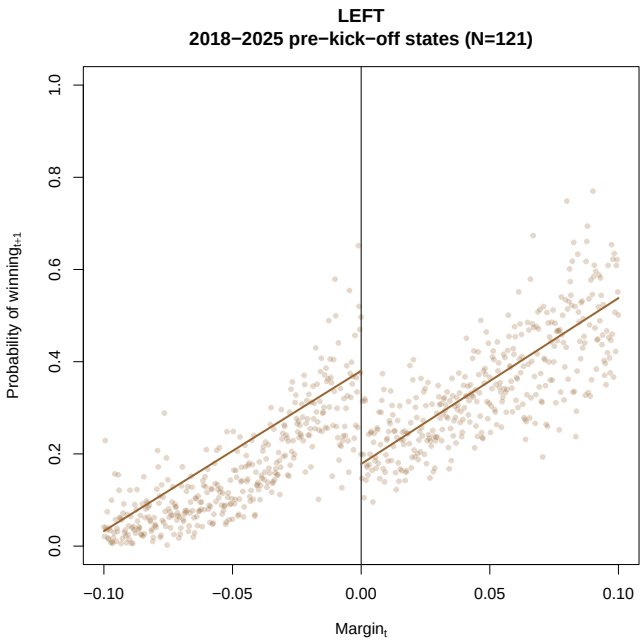
Replication of Lucardi–Rosas 1997–2017

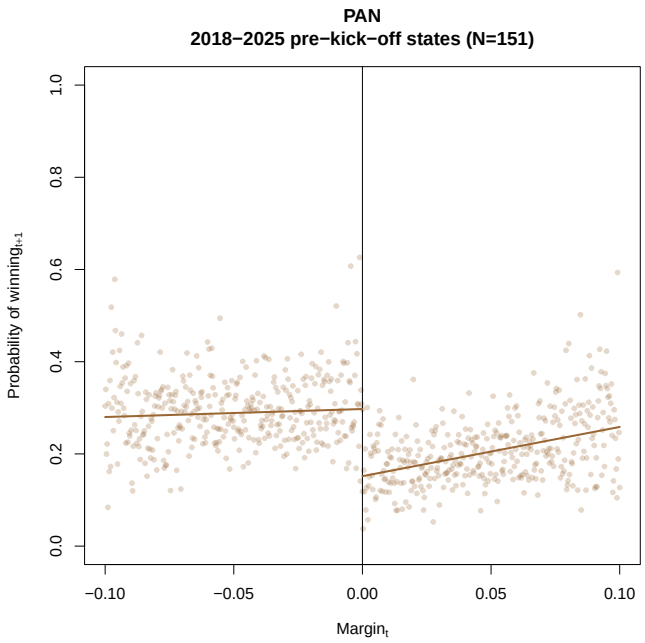


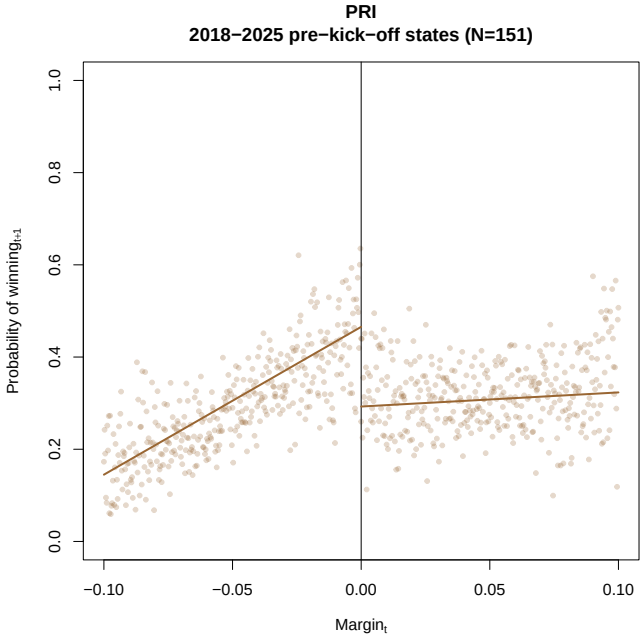




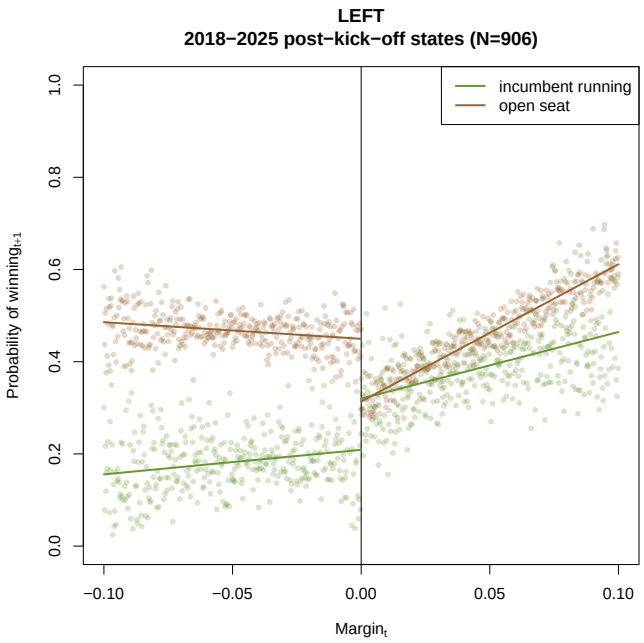
2018–2025 pre-kick-off

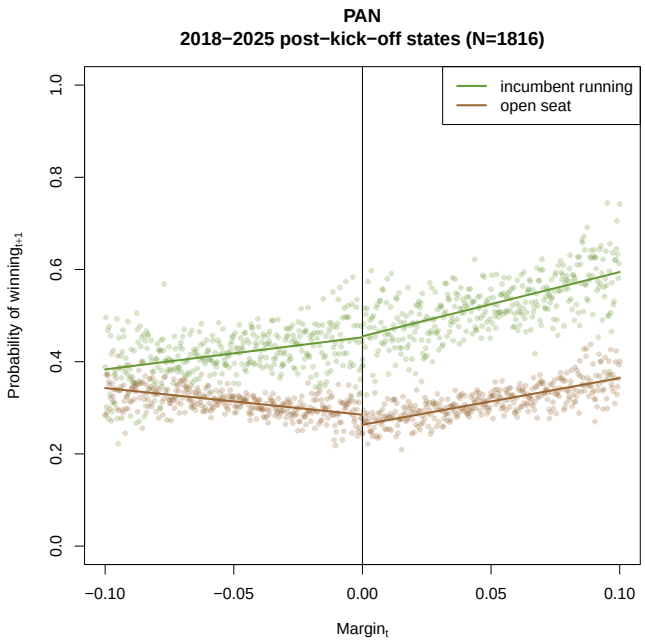


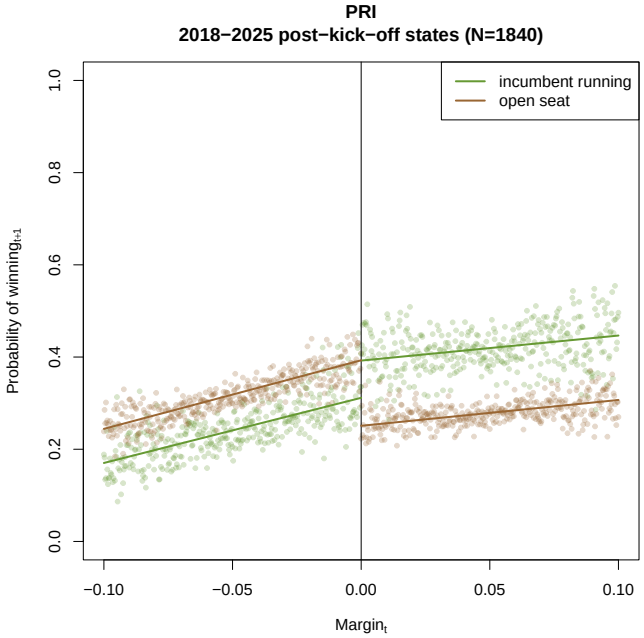




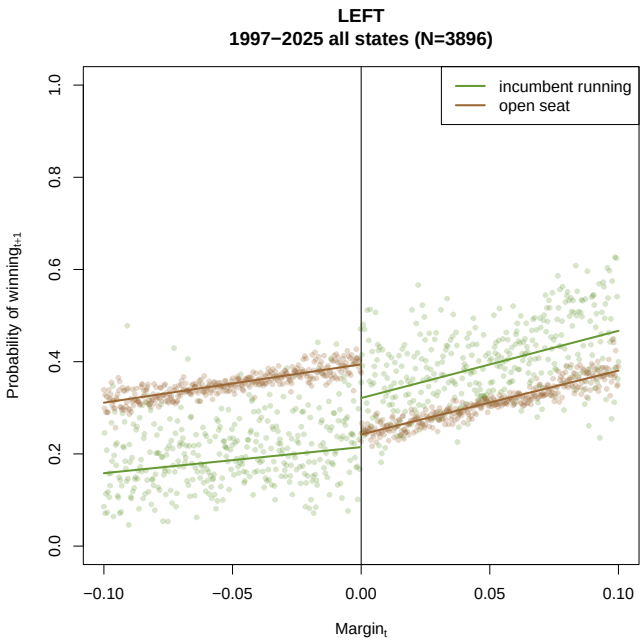
2018–2025 post-kick-off

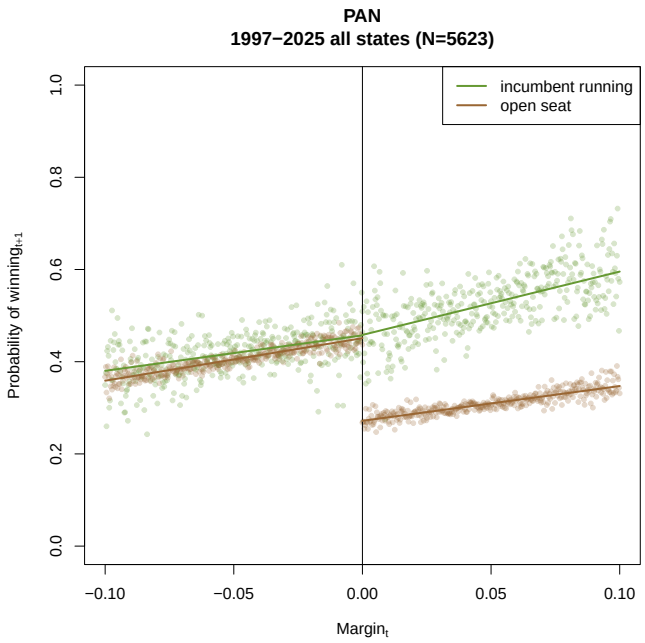


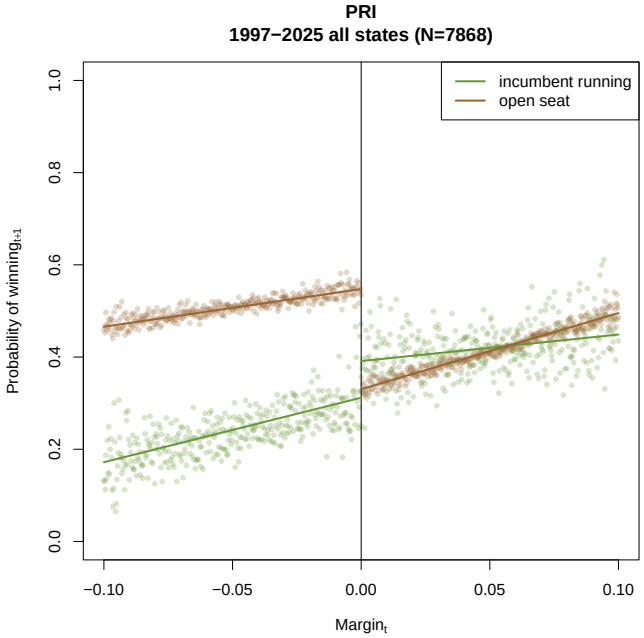




Pooling 1997–2025







Tests: share of posterior draw conforming with

Party	incumbent ran $(\alpha_0 + \alpha_1) > (\beta_0 + \beta_1)$	not $(\alpha_0 > \beta_0)$	N
1997–2017 all municipalities			
Left	—	1.000	2,869
PAN	—	1.000	3,656
PRI	—	1.000	5,877
2018–2025 pre-kick-off municipalities			
Morena	—	0.916	121
PAN	—	0.876	151
PRI	—	0.858	151
2018–2025 post-kick-off municipalities			
Morena	0.219	0.984	906
PAN	0.488	0.677	1,816
PRI	0.177	0.999	1,840
1997–2025 all municipalities			
Left	0.225	1.000	3,896
PAN	0.504	1.000	5,623
PRI	0.189	1.000	7,868

Wrap-up

- Before kick-off: incumbency curse permeated post-AMLO
- After: an incumbent running mitigated/inverted it
- Unlike state assemblies, reform effect is sizeable among municipal executives
  $\rightarrow$ mayors with key sources of patronage in spoils system
- Did counter-reformers kill an insurance policy against negative swings?

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